

“A little bit...”

Meekness and prayer for our neighbor (and even our enemies)

The Orthodox Christian faith is full of life-giving truth, but it is also very complex and even overwhelming to beginners. It is not at all like the typical Western expression of Christianity, and this is part of the reason why it is so overwhelming and seems too big to many people. These small postings are in attempt to give “**A Little Bit**” of knowledge and edification regarding Orthodox Christianity. Since they come from my mind, they are not necessarily organized, but they are absolutely from the heart. It may be very hard to learn all the fasting rules and to go to long services and to read the Fathers, or even the Bible, but it is not so hard to read or listen to or watch a short video about something that is just “**A Little Bit**” about Christianity. [Priest Seraphim Holland](#), who is learning a little bit each day about how to be a real Christian.

Let’s all agree on a fundamental fact about ourselves, as ugly is that fact may be. There are people in our lives, whether we see them regularly or occasionally or they are in our far past (or even – dead), whom we don’t like or we have bad thoughts about. Let’s all agree that at least hypothetically we would like to change this, and not ever feel any bad thoughts about anybody. Let’s also agree that we don’t have it within our own power to completely scrub our mind of bad thoughts about people. The Scripture says that “With men this is impossible; but with God all things are possible” (Matthew 19:26). The “this” can be anything that you do not have power over.

Let’s further agree that if you do not work on something you cannot improve. So, if we have bad thoughts about people and we want to stop having those bad thoughts we must *do something*, and with God’s grace helping us, as hard as it seems it might be - even impossible to us, we can change.

I read the “Ladder of Divine Ascent” every Great Lent. It is a classic spiritual book that has been read for many centuries by Orthodox Christians, whether they be monastics or laypeople. It is my favorite Orthodox Christian book. It is a complicated book, but all complicated things are full of many simple things. Below, is something from this book about “meekness”. The process of becoming truly meek, that is giving ourselves wholly over to God’s will and never being upset when our own will is not fulfilled, is very complex and very hard. When we break down this process into simple parts it seems a little bit easier. Below, is a simple part of becoming meek.

“Meekness consists in praying calmly and sincerely for a troublesome neighbor.” (Step 24.3)

There you have it! A simple part of becoming meek. If you want to have meekness in your heart, then at least pray for people who are troublesome to you. For now, let’s not worry about the “calmly and sincerely” part of the advice given, above. Let’s at least pray for people who trouble us. If we continue to pray for them, then surely God’s grace will help us to change our attitude concerning them.

This step is both easy and very hard. It is easy because all we need do is utter a prayer for our nemesis, in the privacy of our own home. It is hard because there are thoughts that resist anything kind regarding someone who has harmed us or who elicits in us dark thoughts.

Try this! Pray for the difficult people in your life. If you do not know how to pray for them, then just simply write down their name on a list, and every morning or evening, say “Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy upon thy servant (name)”. You can even shorten this to just: “Lord have mercy on (name)”. This can be enough, or you can add other things. It’s not important *what* you pray as much as that *you do pray*.

Try this! Perhaps you have one or two or 30 people that are troublesome to you. Even if you have 30 people, it may take you a minute or two minutes to pray for those people that are troublesome in your life. If you are praying not only to try to care for them, but also with the expression in your heart to God that you want to change and become meek and love everyone as He loves everyone, then surely God will help you.

This is been just “a little bit” about how to love your neighbor and become meek. 3/19/2018 ns

<http://www.orthodox.net/a-little-bit/alb-meekness-and-prayer-for-our-neighbor.doc>

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